

Toothed whales and dolphins

Most of the world's whales are not filter-feeding baleen whales, but fish-eating toothed whales. There are 71 different species, which include the giant sperm whale, the long-tusked narwhal, and many types of dolphins and porpoises. Unlike the filter-feeding whales, toothed whales chase and catch individual animals such as large fish, squid, and even seals and other whales.

SLEEK HUNTERS

The most well-known toothed whales are dolphins. These sleek, powerful, high-speed hunters are sociable and intelligent animals. They travel in large groups, and work together to round up schools of fish and squid. Dolphins are known for the wide variety of sounds they make, including clicks, whistles, and squeaks, which they use to stay in touch while hunting. Each dolphin also has its own special whistle, which acts as its name, and is used by other dolphins to attract its attention.

WOW!

Scientists have taught some dolphins a form of sign language, allowing the scientists and dolphins to talk to each other.



WHALE TEETH

Unlike the teeth of most mammals, whale teeth are simple conical pegs, similar to those of crocodiles. They are good for grabbing prey such as fish, but not for cutting it up or chewing it. Some whales have more than 100 teeth, others hardly any. The biggest teeth belong to the sperm whale, shown below, weighing up to 2.2 lb (1 kg) each.

